

LocalLink Market User Manual

Customer and administrator guide for the LocalLink PHP/MySQL marketplace.

This manual explains the implemented LocalLink Market website, the technology used to build it, the main functions available to customers and administrators, and the exact steps required to use each core workflow.

1. System Overview

LocalLink Market is a simplified college ecommerce platform built around three main areas: a storefront for product browsing, a customer account area for ordering and order history, and a small administrator area for basic store oversight.

The current scope intentionally focuses on the implemented customer and administrator flows. A seller toggle remains visible in navigation, but the submission-ready feature set documented here is the streamlined storefront, checkout, dashboard, and admin toolset.

2. Access and Demo Accounts

Item	Value
Primary local URL	http://localhost/locallink-market/
Customer demo login	buyer@locallink.market / Buyer123!
Administrator demo login	admin@locallink.market / Admin123!
Database setup files	database/schema.sql and database/seed.sql
Local deployment helper	deploy-xampp.ps1

3. Technical Stack

The table below lists the technologies used in the LocalLink site and the purpose of each part of the stack.

Layer	Technology	How It Is Used In LocalLink
Backend language	PHP	Renders the pages, handles form submissions, manages login sessions, and processes checkout and admin actions.

Web server	Apache via XAMPP	Hosts the application locally under localhost for development and demonstration.
Database	MySQL / MariaDB	Stores users, categories, products, and orders in the locallink_market database.
Database access	PDO	Connects PHP to MySQL with prepared statements and exception-based error handling.
Frontend structure	HTML5	Defines the page layouts for the home page, product pages, login/register screens, checkout, and dashboards.
Styling	CSS3	Provides the LocalLink visual design through assets/css/styling.css, including layouts, cards, forms, and dashboard styling.
Client-side behaviour	Vanilla JavaScript	Handles the mobile navigation toggle and live checkout total updates in assets/js/app.js.
Authentication	PHP sessions + password hashing	Tracks signed-in users with session data and verifies passwords securely.
Data model	users, categories, products, orders tables	Supports the implemented marketplace flows for accounts, catalog browsing, and purchasing.
Media assets	Local SVG/JPG assets	Supplies product illustrations and images stored under assets/images/.

4. System Features

LocalLink provides separate feature sets for customers and administrators. The current version is intentionally smaller than the earlier multi-role concept so the implemented workflows remain clear and manageable.

4.1 Customer Features

Feature	Description
Homepage and category browsing	Customers can open the homepage, review the featured products, and move into the catalog by clicking category cards or Browse Products.
Product catalog search and	The products page supports keyword search, category filtering, and

filters	price/newest sorting.
Product detail page	Each product page shows the item image, category, description, stock status, and a direct Buy now action.
Customer registration	New users can create a customer account using name, email address, and password.
Secure login	Returning users sign in with email and password and are redirected to the correct dashboard.
Checkout flow	Customers choose quantity, delivery method, payment option, and optional notes before placing an order.
Order history dashboard	Signed-in customers can review order totals, order status, and account details from the buyer dashboard.

4.2 Administrator Features

Feature	Description
Admin-only dashboard access	Administrator accounts are protected and redirected to the admin dashboard after login.
Store statistics	The dashboard summarises total users, products, orders, and revenue.
Latest customer orders	Administrators can review a recent orders table showing order code, customer, quantity, status, total, and date.
Latest user signups	The dashboard lists recently created user accounts with role and joined date.
Add product form	Administrators can create new products by entering the product title, category, price, stock level, and short description.
Catalog management scope	The current admin scope is intentionally focused on product creation and reporting instead of advanced moderation or seller approval workflows.

5. Operational Guide

This section explains how to use each major workflow on the site. The screenshots were captured from the running LocalLink application hosted locally through XAMPP.

5.1 Open the Homepage and Browse the Storefront

Use the homepage to understand the project scope, move into the catalog, and jump into registration or login.

Step	Action
1	Open the site in a browser using <code>http://localhost/locallink-market/</code> .
2	Review the hero section to see the project summary and the main call-to-action buttons.
3	Click Browse Products to open the catalog, or click Create Account if you are a new customer.
4	Use the category cards lower on the page if you want to browse a specific product category immediately.

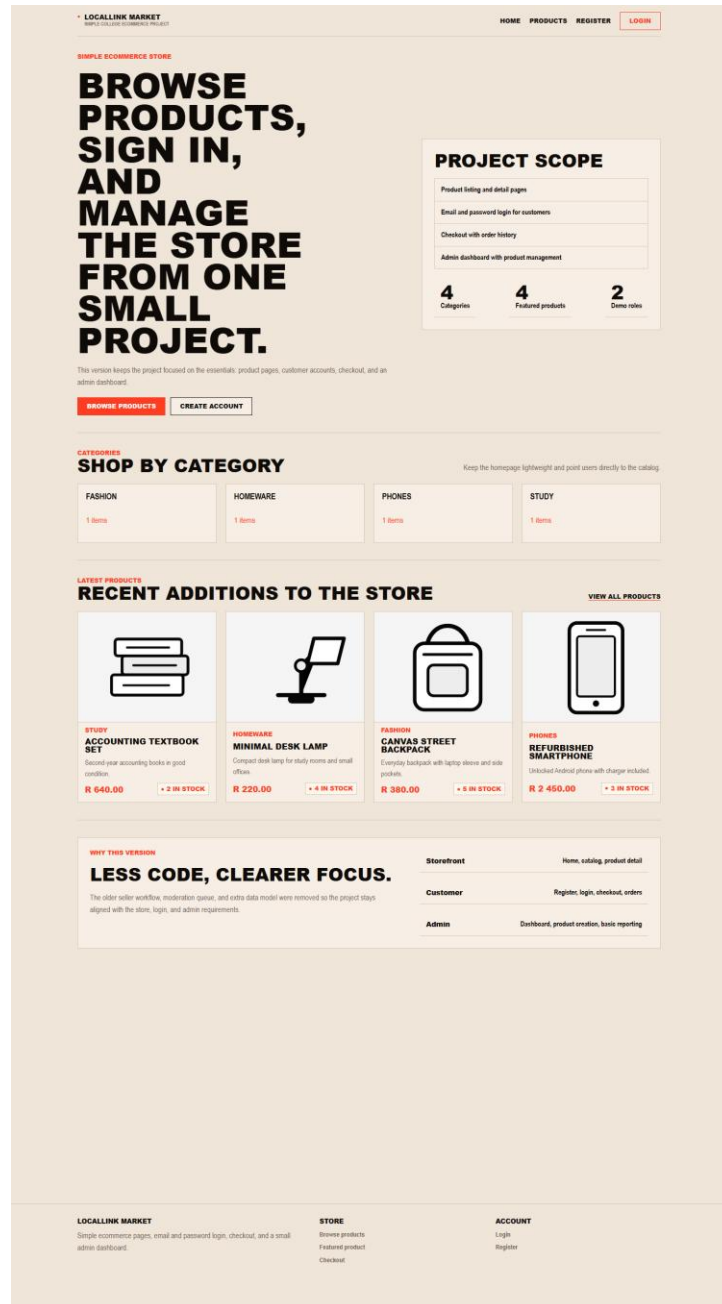


Figure 1. LocalLink homepage with category shortcuts, featured products, and account entry points.

5.2 Search, Filter, and Sort Products

The products page is the main catalog screen for finding the correct item quickly.

Step	Action
1	Open Products from the top navigation bar or the homepage.

2	Type a keyword in the Search field if you know part of the product name.
3	Choose a category from the Category dropdown if you want to narrow the list.
4	Use the Sort dropdown to arrange products by newest first or lowest price.
5	Click Apply filters to refresh the list, or Clear to reset the catalog view.

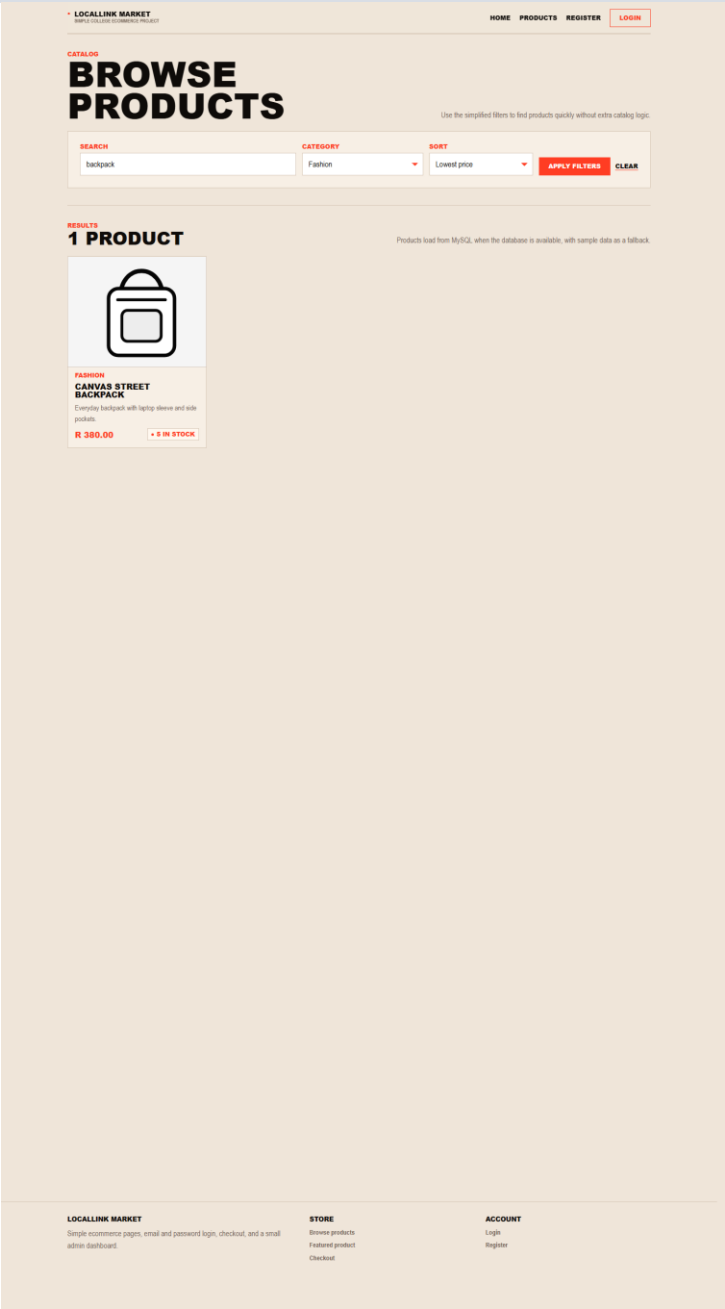


Figure 2. Product catalog with keyword search, category filter, and sorting controls.

5.3 View Product Details

Each product card links to a dedicated detail page where the customer can inspect the item before buying it.

Step	Action
1	From the homepage or products page, click on a product card or product title.
2	Review the product image, category label, price, stock level, and description.
3	Use Buy now to move directly into checkout for that item, or Back to products to continue browsing.

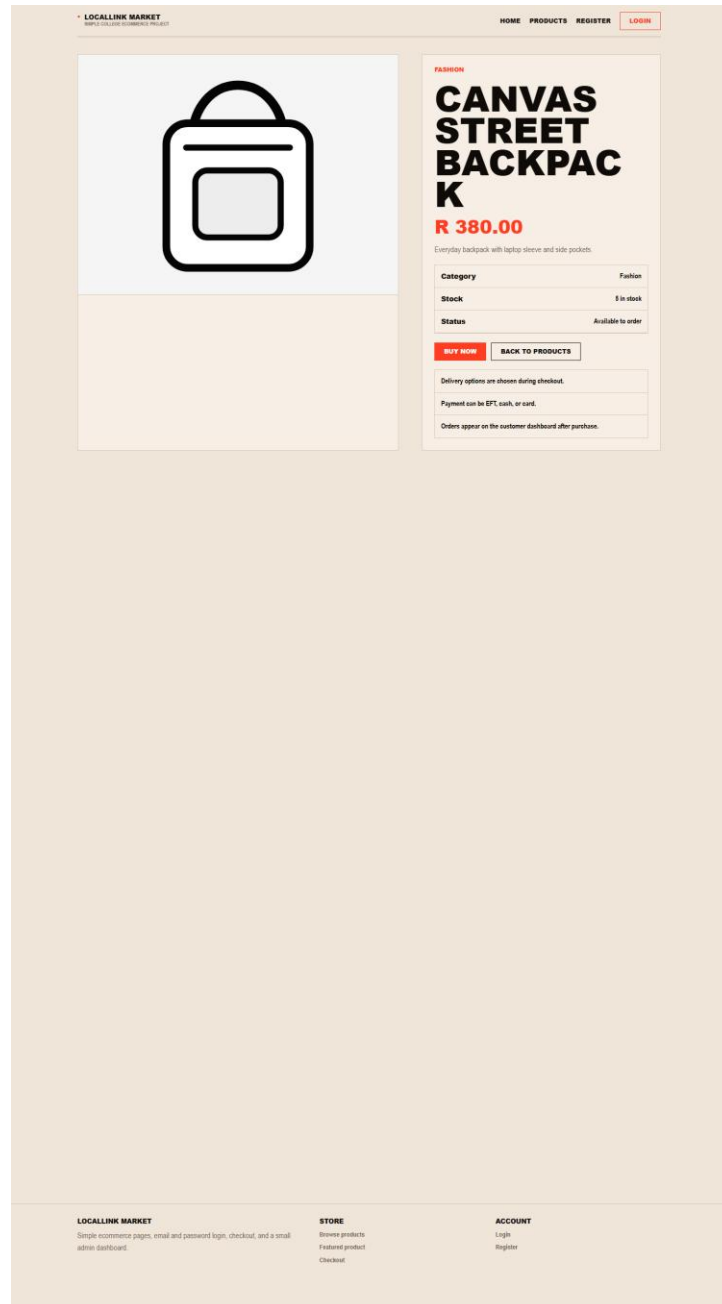


Figure 3. Product detail page with pricing, stock information, and the Buy now action.

5.4 Create a Customer Account

Public registration is available for customer accounts only. Administrator accounts are seeded directly through the database.

Step	Action
1	Open Register from the top navigation or homepage.

2	Enter your full name, valid email address, and a password with at least eight characters.
3	Click Create account to submit the form.
4	After a successful registration, continue to the login page and sign in with the new customer account.

LOCALLINK MARKET
SIMPLY COLLECT. SIMPLY CHECKOUT. PROJECT

HOME PRODUCTS REGISTER LOGIN

CREATE ACCOUNT

REGISTER AS A CUSTOMER

This simplified project no longer includes seller requests or extra role setup during registration.

Use one account to browse and order products

View order history after checkout

Admin accounts are seeded from the database instead of the public form

REGISTRATION FORM

FULL NAME

Full name

EMAIL ADDRESS

you@example.com

PASSWORD

Create password

CREATE ACCOUNT

USE OF THIS CHECKOUT TOOL, CUSTOMER REGISTRATION IS THE ONLY PUBLIC SETUP FLOW.

LOCALLINK MARKET
Simple ecommerce pages, email and password login, checkout, and a small admin dashboard.

STORE
Browse products
Featured product
Checkout

ACCOUNT
Login
Register

Figure 4. Customer registration form used to create a new public account.

5.5 Sign In to the Site

Both customers and administrators use the same login page. The system redirects each user to the correct dashboard based on the account role.

Step	Action
1	Open the Login page from the top navigation.
2	Enter your email address and password.
3	Click Sign in.
4	Customers are redirected to the buyer dashboard, while administrators are redirected to the admin dashboard.

The image is a wireframe of a web application for 'LOCALLINK MARKET'. At the top, a navigation bar contains the site name 'LOCALLINK MARKET' and a sub-header 'MARKET COLLECTOR MARKET PROJECT'. To the right of the navigation bar are links for 'HOME', 'PRODUCTS', and 'REGISTER', followed by a red 'LOGIN' button. The main content area is split into two columns. The left column has a section titled 'ACCOUNT LOGIN' with a large 'SIGN IN' heading. Below the heading is a paragraph stating that the project now uses only standard email and password login, with social login and role-heavy auth removed. Underneath is a table with three rows: 'Customer dashboard for order history', 'Admin dashboard for product and store oversight', and 'Secure access for buyers, sellers, and administrators'. The right column contains a 'LOGIN FORM' with a red sub-header. It has two input fields: 'EMAIL ADDRESS' (with the placeholder 'you@example.com') and 'PASSWORD' (with the placeholder 'Enter password'). At the bottom of the form are two buttons: a red 'SIGN IN' button and a 'CREATE A NEW ACCOUNT' button. The footer of the page is divided into three sections: 'LOCALLINK MARKET' (describing simple ecommerce pages like login, checkout, and admin dashboard), 'STORE' (listing browse products, featured product, and checkout), and 'ACCOUNT' (listing login and register).

Figure 5. Shared login page for both customer and administrator accounts.

5.6 Complete Checkout

Checkout is only available to signed-in customers. The form captures order quantity, delivery, payment preference, and an optional note.

Step	Action
1	Log in as a customer and open a product detail page.

2	Click Buy now to open checkout for that specific item.
3	Confirm the quantity in the Order details section.
4	Choose a delivery method: standard delivery, express delivery, or collection.
5	Choose the payment method. If card is selected, fill in the simulated card fields.
6	Add any order note if needed, then click Pay and place order.
7	After the order is created, the system redirects back to the buyer dashboard where the order appears in history.

LOCALLINK MARKET

EMERGENCY COLLECTOR ECONOMICS PROJECT

HOME

PRODUCTS

NOTES

SELLER

ACCOUNT

LOGOUT

CHECKOUT

PAYMENT AND DELIVERY

KEEP SHOPPING

1. ORDER DETAILS

CONFIRM YOUR ITEM

CANVAS STREET BACKPACK

Fashion

5 in stock

QUANTITY

1

2. DELIVERY

CHOOSE HANDOVER

STANDARD DELIVERY

R 45.00

EXPRESS DELIVERY

R 55.00

COLLECT FROM SELLER

Free

3. PAYMENT

SIMULATE PAYMENT

MOCK CARD

Simulated

EFT

Simulated

CASH

On handover

NAME ON CARD

Hand Partner

CARD NUMBER

6302 6302 6302 6302

EXPIRY

MMYY

CVV

123

THIS IS A SIMULATED CHECKOUT FOR THE PROJECT. NO REAL CARD IS CHARGED.

4. NOTES

MESSAGE THE SELLER

ORDER NOTES

Preferred delivery time or collection note

PAY AND PLACE ORDER

ORDER SUMMARY

TOTAL

R 425,00

Item price

R 380.00

Subtotal

R 380.00

Delivery

R 45.00

Payment status

Simulated

REVIEW

DELIVERY

PAYMENT

SAVED ORDER

LOCALLINK MARKET

Single e-commerce pages, email and password login, checkout, and a small admin dashboard.

STORE

Browse products

Featured product

Checkout

ACCOUNT

My account

Login

Seller view

Figure 6. Checkout page showing quantity, delivery, payment, notes, and the live order summary.

5.7 Review the Buyer Dashboard

The buyer dashboard acts as the customer account area and provides a record of previous orders.

Step	Action
1	Sign in with a customer account.

2	Open My Account or allow the post-login redirect to take you to the dashboard.
3	Review the summary cards for total orders, open orders, and total spent.
4	Check the order history table for order number, product, quantity, status, total, and date.
5	Use Browse products or Shop now if you want to return to the store.

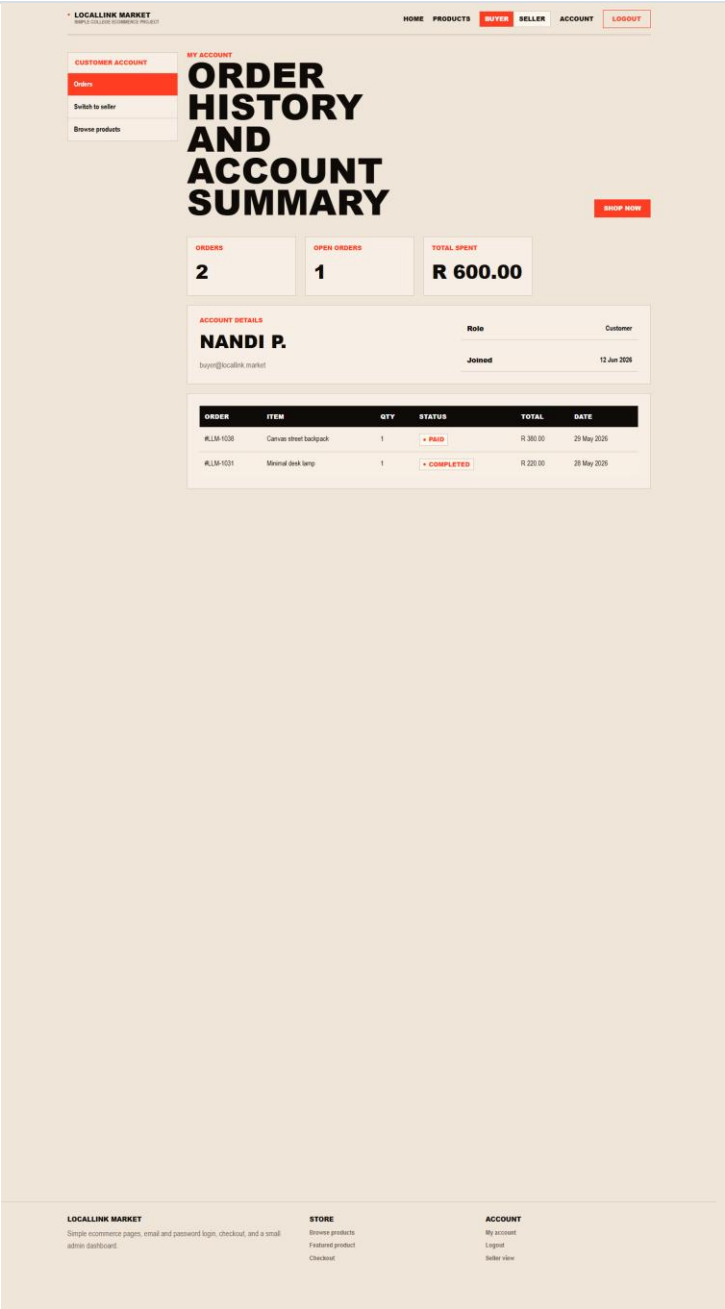


Figure 7. Buyer dashboard with account details, order summary cards, and order history.

5.8 Open and Use the Admin Dashboard

The administrator dashboard is the control surface for store reporting and quick oversight.

Step	Action
1	Sign in with the administrator account.
2	After login, the site redirects automatically to the admin dashboard.
3	Review the summary cards for Users, Products, Orders, and Revenue.
4	Use the Recent orders table to monitor current purchases.
5	Use the Recent users table to review the latest signups.
6	Use the left sidebar or Add Product button to move into product creation.

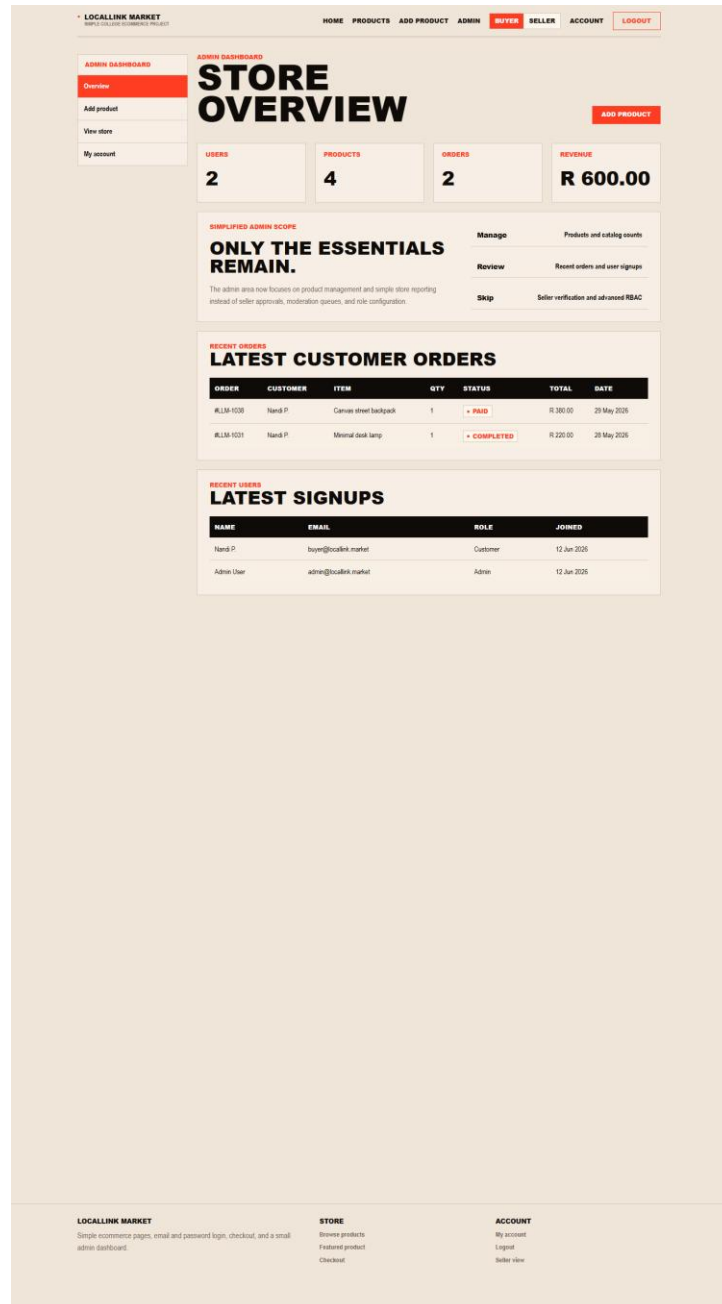


Figure 8. Administrator dashboard with store statistics, recent orders, and recent user signups.

5.9 Add a Product as an Administrator

Product creation is handled from the administrator side in the current LocalLink scope.

Step	Action
1	Log in as an administrator and open Add product from the sidebar or dashboard button.

2	Enter the product title.
3	Choose the correct category from the dropdown list.
4	Enter the price, stock quantity, and a short description.
5	Click Save product to add the new listing to the database.
6	Return to the admin dashboard or the storefront to confirm that the product has been created.

• **LOCALLINK MARKET**
Simple ecommerce pages, email and password login, checkout, and a small admin dashboard.

HOMEPRODUCTSADD PRODUCTADMINBUYERSELLERACCOUNTLOGOUT

ADMIN PRODUCT MANAGEMENT

ADD A NEW PRODUCT

Products are now created from the admin side instead of a separate seller workflow.

Choose a category

Set the price and stock

Add a short description for the product page

PRODUCT FORM

PRODUCT TITLE

Product name

CATEGORY

Fashion

PRICE

0.00

STOCK

1

DESCRIPTION

Short product description

SAVE PRODUCT

CLICK PRODUCT IMAGE & DEFAULT IMAGE BASED ON THE SELECTED CATEGORY TO KEEP THE PRODUCT SMALL.

LOCALLINK MARKET
Simple ecommerce pages, email and password login, checkout, and a small admin dashboard.

STORE
Browse products
Featured product
Checkout

ACCOUNT
My account
Logout
Seller view

Figure 9. Administrator add-product form for catalog management.

6. Closing Notes

LocalLink Market was implemented as a lightweight PHP/MySQL marketplace focused on the required customer and administrator flows. The manual therefore concentrates on the features that are active in the current codebase: browsing, registration, login, checkout, order history, admin reporting, and product creation.

If the system is run on a new machine, import `database/schema.sql` and `database/seed.sql` first, then start MySQL and Apache through XAMPP before using the demo accounts listed in this document.